

Writing an essay (type 1)

DISCUSS THE TOPIC

- What sort of crimes involve driving?
- What do you think the ideal age for getting a driver's licence should be? Why?

SAMPLE WRITING

Read the rubric below. Is it possible to contradict the question in the rubric? What does this indicate about the answer in the essay below?



Your teacher has asked you to write a composition on the following topic:

Why is driving without a licence considered a crime?

Write your composition. (120-180 words)

Now read the two essays, A and B, below. Which do you think is the better essay and why?

Essay A

Nowadays driving has become an essential part of everyday life with the majority of people owning a car. One fact that drivers should take seriously, though, is that they should have a driver's licence, because driving without a licence is indeed a crime.

Firstly, although the laws are different around the world, one thing is certain - driving without a licence is against the law everywhere. Often, police will stop drivers to check that all necessary documents are in order. As a matter of fact, heavy fines and even imprisonment are punishments which are handed out to offenders.

Apart from being against the law, driving without a licence is also extremely dangerous. Lack of proper driving instruction may be the cause of road accidents, and consequently this poses a threat to other drivers and pedestrians. These accidents could even prove fatal and as a result, drivers are likely to face charges as serious as manslaughter.

To sum up, there is no doubt that driving without a licence is an act prohibited and punished by law. Of course, this should be the case to ensure the safety of the general public.

Essay B

Everyone has a car nowadays and uses it quite a lot. Everyone, though, should have a licence. It's a serious matter. Doesn't everyone know that driving without a licence is a crime? I know at least five people who are now driving without a licence. (5)

It's obvious that the laws are different around the world. One thing is the same, though. That driving without a licence is against the law, isn't it? I think it's great that police stop drivers to check that everything is OK. People who drive without a licence are given - and rightfully - punishments e.g. fines or even prison sentences. (10)

You see, driving without a licence is against the law. It's also dangerous. Because these people haven't had proper driving instruction, they are probably going to cause accidents. This is a threat to other drivers and pedestrians. Someone could get killed, you know. So, some people even end up in jail. I'm glad about that because they deserve it. (15)

For sure, driving without a licence is against the law. I believe it should always be so, to make sure that innocent people are safe. Personally, I would never drive without a licence. (20)

Read the two essays again. Then, complete the chart below by writing whether the characteristics listed apply to the essays, giving examples. The first one has been done for you.

CHARACTERISTICS	ESSAY A	ESSAY B
language	Frequent use of formal language used throughout the essay. e.g. "One fact that drivers should take seriously..." (ℓ 3-4)	Frequent use of conversational language. e.g. "You see" (ℓ 15), "you know" (ℓ 20-21), "For sure" (ℓ 23)
range of grammatical structures		
use of first person singular (I)		
range of vocabulary		
linking words/phrases		
abbreviations/contractions		
rhetorical questions		

PLAN

There are two main types of essays (compositions). The first type (dealt with in this unit) presents only one side of an issue, whereas the second type (Unit 13) presents both sides of an issue.

You write a one-sided essay if:

- 1 you are asked to list suggestions, problems, solutions to problems etc.
- 2 the rubric is worded in such a way that it does not allow you to express the opposite point of view. In this case, you should not mention the opposite point of view (opinion essay).
- 3 you choose to discuss the issue only from one point of view and not mention the opposite point of view at all (opinion essay).

Below is a general plan of a one-sided essay, with questions to help you when planning one. Read the plan and compare it to the sample.

Introduction	• introduce the subject of the essay • state your opinion (if required)	What are you going to discuss? What is your opinion? (if required)
Main part (2-3 paragraphs)	• present your ideas in an organised and clear way • support your ideas/points with arguments	What ideas/points are you going to discuss? What suggestions are you going to make? How are you going to justify your ideas/points?
Conclusion	• summarise your points • close with a general comment	What is your overall opinion? What recommendations can you make?

GUIDE TO WRITING

- Underline the key words in the rubric and come up with ideas and a plan about what you are going to write.
- Choose a few of your ideas/points and expand on them. Explain them clearly, justifying them, supporting them with reasons or examples.
- Do not use statistics you cannot support or explain clearly.
- Write in a formal style and never use abbreviated forms or contractions.
- Divide your essay into paragraphs. Present every major point in a separate paragraph.
- Use topic sentences to introduce each paragraph.
- Don't present your ideas in the introduction. Instead, write a general statement about the issue.
- Use linking words/phrases. Look at the table below for ideas.

listing points	firstly, to begin/start with, in the first place, finally, last but not least
adding more points	in addition to this, furthermore, moreover, what is more, also, apart from this, besides, another point worth mentioning is
giving an example	for example, such as, particularly, especially, take for instance
emphasising	in fact, as a matter of fact
expressing contrast	although, in spite of, despite, however, but
expressing cause/reason	because (of), as, since, due to, owing to
expressing result/consequence	therefore, in this case, for this reason, consequently, as a result
summing up	in conclusion, to sum up, all in all, on the whole, taking everything into account
giving your opinion	in my opinion/view, personally, I believe, the way I see it, from my point of view, I am in favour of, my belief is that

- REMEMBER: quantity is not quality! Also, going over the word limit is not a good idea as marks are usually deducted.

- Write your essay in an impersonal way. Avoid using "I" too often.
- Use a range of vocabulary and grammatical structures. Avoid being too simple.
- Don't introduce new ideas/points in the conclusion.

WRITING PRACTICE

- 1 a. Read carefully the introduction to an essay below. Then decide which of the topics, A-C in the rubric is appropriate. Why are the other two inappropriate?

Your teacher has asked you to write a composition on the topic:

- A. There are many social problems in the twenty-first century. Discuss a few.
- B. Teenagers should not be sent to prison.
- C. Suggest ways of reducing the number of teenagers that go to prison.

Write your composition. (120-180 words)

As we enter the twenty-first century, we are faced with new social problems. One of them is that a large number of inmates in prison are teenagers. Exposure to prison and society's misgivings makes it quite difficult for teenagers to readjust to the "outside world". This is why teenagers should not be sent to prison.

- b. Read the topic sentences provided for the two paragraphs of the main part and use the ideas given to complete the paragraphs. Don't forget to use linking words/phrases.

To begin with, once in prison, teenagers are exposed to many dangers. _____

Another serious reason is that once out of prison, these teenagers find it very difficult to get a job. _____

IDEAS

- socialise with hardened criminals
- become more aggressive
- may become addicted to drugs
- vicious circle of crime
- criminal record forever
- usually not qualified
- employers do not trust ex-criminals
- do not find "good" jobs

c. Complete the conclusion of the essay.

In conclusion, it is obvious that alternative methods of punishing teenagers should be found. _____

2 a. Read the rubric below. How is the essay you are asked to write different from the ones in the sections **SAMPLE WRITING** and **WRITING PRACTICE (1)** of this unit?

Your class has been doing a project on crime. Your teacher has asked you to write a composition on the topic:

Suggest ways to make your home and neighbourhood safer from crime.

Write your composition. (120-180 words)



b. Read the rubric again and try to come up with ideas to complete the table.

SUGGESTIONS	JUSTIFICATIONS

3 Read the rubric below and in the space provided make a plan of what you would include in the main part of the essay.

Your teacher has asked you to write a composition on the following topic:

Football hooligans are a problem to society. Why is this so?

Write your composition. (120-180 words)

4 Tasks for homework.

- Write an essay using some of the suggestions and justifications you discussed in exercise 2.
- Write an essay using the plan you made in exercise 3.